

Basic Life Support Algorithm

Approach safely

Check response

Shout for help

Call 999

Open Airways

Check breathing

30 Chest

2 Rescue Breaths



Descriptions of specific skills

Warning!

These are **practical skills** – you need to be able to **demonstrate** them, not just **describe** them.

They are best learnt in the practical sessions, but if you need a quick reminder, they are described here.

How to check for responsiveness

Use the “Shake and Shout” technique:

1. Give a direct command: “Hello, can you hear me? Can you open your eyes please?”
2. Speak clearly and loudly, close to casualty into both ears

This is important as a patient with decreased consciousness may still respond to direct commands.

How to shout for help

It is important to ask for two things: help and an AED (Automated external defibrillator – *covered in week 2*)

1. “Help, help! Can I have some assistance please? Can someone fetch an AED?”

How to call an ambulance

You may access an ambulance via either 999 or 112 in the UK. You

must give the emergency services 5 pieces of information:

1. Your name
2. Your location
3. A means to identify you (*what you are wearing*)
4. The condition of casualty
5. That you are trained in BLS

How to open an airway

This is done using the “Head--tilt, chin--lift” technique.

Often, the most important action you can do for a casualty is to open and maintain their airway. This is because while someone is unconscious, their tongue may fall backwards into the throat and cause their airway to be blocked. By performing the Head tilt and Chin lift the airway will be opened and allow the easy passage of air into the lungs.

1. Place the palm of your hand nearest the top of their head on their forehead
2. Place two fingers on the bony part of the chin
Take care not to press on the non--bony parts further back as this can make the situation worse
3. Use both hands to rotate the head backwards, opening the airway

How to check for breathing

This is done following a “Head--tilt, chin--lift” whilst holding the head in position.

1. Put your ear next to the casualty’s mouth and look at their chest
2. Check for the **3 signs of breathing**:
 - a. Look *Look for movement of the chest*
 - b. Listen *Listen for breath sounds*
 - c. Feel *Feels for their breath on your cheek*
3. Take no more than 10 seconds to check.

The following signs are features of **abnormal** breathing and show that **CPR is required**:

- Infrequent gasping breaths
- Infrequent laboured breaths

How to perform cardiopulmonary resuscitation

CPR (cardiopulmonary resuscitation) is a simple procedure:

1. Deliver 30 chest compressions
2. Deliver 2 rescue breaths
3. Repeat from step 1 until:
 - a. Someone else is able to take over
 - b. The casualty recovers
 - c. You become too exhausted to continue

How to perform chest compressions

Good chest compressions have:

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| 1. Good posture | <i>One hand over the other, straight arms, locked elbows</i> |
| 2. Good hand position | <i>The centre of the chest (don’t use the nipples to judge!)</i> |
| 3. Good rate | <i>100 – 120 per minute</i> |
| 4. Good depth | <i>5 – 6cm</i> |

Good quality compressions are very important in **buying time** for the arrival of more comprehensive care.
Do not be concerned about breaking ribs etc.

How to perform rescue breaths

Good rescue breaths have:

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|-----------------|---|
| 1. Open airway | <i>Perform and hold a “head--tilt, chin--lift”</i> |
| 2. Good seal | <i>Pinch the nose and make a good mouth--to--mouth seal</i> |
| 3. Good volume | <i>A normal quiet breath – don’t overfill</i> |
| 4. Good speed | <i>Take around 1 second then let the chest fall</i> |
| 5. Right number | <i>Do no more than 2</i> |

Don't let rescue breaths interrupt chest compressions – if the breaths don't go in, make no more than 2 attempts, and then return to chest compressions.